Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on William Butler Yeats's "To a Child dancing in the Wind"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in offering an analysis of the speaker's warning to the child in Yeats's "To a Child dancing in the Wind" include

alliteration,
anthropomorphism,
apostrophe,
couplet,
eye rhyme,
feminine rhyme,
iamb,
masculine rhyme,
metaphor,
metonymy,
onomatopoeia,
personification,
ploce,
rhetorical question,
theme, and
tone.

The contestant should address the speaker's list of examples pointing to the child's innocence: "not know[ing] / The fool's triumph" (lines 6-7); losing love immediately upon finding it (7-8); the harvest's being delayed, the "best labourer dead" (9-10)—a list bracketed by the metaphorical facing of the proverbial storm (lines 1-5; 11-12) that is, as the kiddos say, adulting.

The speaker's turning to the age-old admonitory adage about a flame and the moths—which, in this case, are "despairing" (line 15) as they approach the liminal moment of death after being allured by something that wrongly ascribes to the world the veneer of benignity: a child's "dream that all the world's a friend" (lines 19-20)—might well serve as the focus of the young writer's analysis of Yeats's poem.

The young contestant should recognize the speaker's realism, perhaps, fatalism, as he advises the child to "[s]uffer as [their] mother suffered, / Be as broken in the end" (21-22).

Something should be made of the speaker's resignation, perhaps his own despairing, in the concluding couplet; the litcritter might recognize the cycle, which includes the experienced adult's not being able to speak the language of the child he once was.